

Wednesday, 15 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Mostly clear 29° 18°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 28° 15°	MANCHESTER Clear 27° 15°	GLASGOW Mostly clear 25° 13°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

Wildfires are continuing to burn across parts of the UK, with fire chiefs warning of extreme pressure on emergency services.

Major incidents were declared in North Wales and in Glossop, Derbyshire, over the weekend. The dry conditions and high temperatures are making it incredibly difficult for firefighters.

ENVIRONMENT · UK
- 2

MPs are expected to approve the long-delayed Hillsborough Law today, a significant step towards justice for the victims.

This legislation has returned to the Commons during Sir Keir Starmer's final days as prime minister. It aims to ensure that public bodies are more accountable in future tragedies.

POLITICS · UK
- 3

A murder investigation has been launched in Northern Ireland after three people, including an eight-year-old girl, were found dead.

Police discovered the bodies in Ballymena on Monday, prompting a major police presence in the area. Our thoughts are with the families affected by this terrible news.

CRIME · UK
- 4

The family of Pete and Fran Gillam, from Sheffield, have confirmed their deaths in the recent wildfires, expressing their heartbreak.

Their family shared the devastating news, highlighting the tragic human cost of the fires. It's a stark reminder of the dangers these blazes pose.

TRAGEDY · UK
- 5

South East Water has been hit with a hefty £30.5 million penalty for its widespread supply failures.

Water regulator Ofwat confirmed the penalty after three separate investigations into the company's performance. It's hoped this will lead to better service for customers.

CONSUMER · UK

What's coming up

1 **Andy Serkis has been defending the casting choices for the new Lord of the Rings series, which features a host of big names.**

Kate Winslet, Jamie Dornan, and Anya Taylor-Joy are among the stars already announced. Serkis addressed concerns about diversity in the upcoming fantasy epic.

ON AIR – Are you excited for a new Lord of the Rings adaptation, and who would you love to see cast?

TV · COMING SOON

2 **California is leading a lawsuit to block the proposed mega-merger between Hollywood giants Paramount and Warner Bros.**

The state, where both studios are headquartered, has joined eleven others in an effort to halt the deal. This could have huge implications for the film industry.

ON AIR – Do you think these big studio mergers are good or bad for cinema and TV?

FILM · FUTURE

3 **A British teenager has beaten over 300,000 hopefuls to become one of the new Cheetah Girls!**

The iconic musical group is making a comeback with a brand new generation of young stars. What an incredible achievement for the talented youngster!

ON AIR – Were you a fan of The Cheetah Girls, and are you excited for their return?

MUSIC · COMING SOON

4 **Several popular country estate festivals, including those at Sandringham and Audley End, have been cancelled due to financial issues.**

Heritage Live announced the cancellations at short notice, leaving many ticket holders disappointed. It's a real shame for fans of live music this summer.

ON AIR – Have you ever had tickets cancelled for a festival or event, and how did you feel about it?

MUSIC · SUMMER

5 **England fans are still buzzing after their World Cup win against Norway, with 'Wonderwall' becoming the unofficial anthem.**

David Beckham himself joined in the latest Oasis singalong following the team's victory in Miami. It seems the classic track is more popular than ever!

ON AIR – What's your go-to song for celebrating a big sporting win?

MUSIC · NOW

On the schedule

1 **Joe Root's brilliant run-a-ball 76 helped England reach 258 in the first One Day International against India at Edgbaston.**

Root rescued the home side with an unbeaten knock, guiding them to a respectable total. It was a crucial innings to set up the match.

ON AIR – How important is Joe Root to England's white-ball team, and what did you make of his performance?

CRICKET · UK

2 **Security is being ramped up for Wednesday's hotly anticipated World Cup semi-final between England and Argentina in Atlanta.**

Authorities have confirmed increased security measures will be in place for the high-stakes match. It's set to be a tense encounter both on and off the pitch.

ON AIR – Are you feeling confident about England's chances against Argentina in the semi-final?

FOOTBALL · WORLD CUP

3 **Could this be the year an Englishman finally wins The Open on home soil, after nearly 60 years?**

The last English winner was Tony Jacklin, but hopes are high this week at Royal Birkdale. It would be a fantastic story for British golf.

ON AIR – Who are you backing to win The Open this year, and do you think an Englishman can do it?

GOLF · UK

4 **England will make a late decision on whether star midfielder Declan Rice is fit to start Wednesday's World Cup semi-final.**

His fitness is a major concern for Gareth Southgate ahead of the crucial clash against Argentina. His presence would be a huge boost for the team.

ON AIR – How vital is Declan Rice to England's midfield, and who should step up if he can't play?

FOOTBALL · WORLD CUP

5 **India secured a historic 270-run victory over England in the women's Test match at Lord's, bowling them out before lunch.**

It was an emphatic win for India, taking the required four wickets quickly on the final day. A tough result for England, but a memorable Test match.

ON AIR – What's your take on the growing popularity and excitement around women's Test cricket?

CRICKET · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A new appreciation for the simple art of 'doodling' is sweeping across offices and homes alike.**
Many are finding that a quick sketch during meetings or phone calls actually helps focus the mind and sparks creativity, rather than being a distraction.
- 2 The trend for 'urban foraging' is growing, with city dwellers learning to identify edible plants in local parks and green spaces.**
It's encouraging people to connect with nature on their doorstep and discover unexpected treats, from wild garlic to elderflower.
- 3 A delightful movement encouraging people to 'write letters to future selves' is gaining popularity.**
Participants write notes to be opened years later, offering advice, reflections, or simply a snapshot of their present thoughts and dreams.
- 4 The surprising joy of 'rediscovering old photo albums' is becoming a popular weekend activity.**
Families are spending quality time together, sifting through physical prints and sharing forgotten stories and cherished memories.
- 5 A charming new trend involves 'decorating garden gnomes' in elaborate, quirky outfits.**
It's bringing a touch of whimsical personality to outdoor spaces, with some gnomes sporting tiny hats, scarves, and even miniature spectacles.
- 6 Many people are finding solace in the meditative practice of 'watching clouds drift by'.**
It's a simple way to pause, de-stress, and appreciate the ever-changing beauty of the sky, offering a moment of calm in busy days.
- 7 The humble 'picnic blanket' is experiencing a resurgence as the ultimate symbol of spontaneous outdoor fun.**
People are embracing the joy of al fresco dining, whether in a park, on a beach, or even in their own back garden.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to figure out a new gadget, even though we know it's probably not the best approach?

ANSWER: PRESSING ALL THE BUTTONS RANDOMLY, HOPING ONE OF THEM WILL MAGICALLY SOLVE THE PROBLEM.

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'word' or 'phrase' they absolutely have to use when describing something delicious they've just eaten. What's their go-to expression?

ANSWER: CALLING IT 'MOREISH' – BECAUSE YOU ALWAYS WANT JUST ONE MORE BITE!

TALK TOPIC

- **You know how sometimes you rediscover an 'old school exercise book' or a diary from your younger days?**
What's the funniest or most surprising thing you've ever found written in one of those blasts from the past?
- **We all have those 'little quirks' when it comes to packing for a trip, don't we?**
What's the one unusual item you absolutely have to pack, no matter where you're going, even if it seems a bit silly?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** A group of pugs is called a 'grumble'.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Butterflies use their antennae to smell, but they taste with their tiny feet.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£25 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£3.8 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The shortest war in history was between Britain and Zanzibar on August 27, 1896, lasting only 38 minutes.
- Cracking your knuckles does not cause arthritis; the sound is gas bubbles bursting in the synovial fluid.
- The world's smallest chameleon, the 'Brookesia nana', is so tiny it can fit on a human fingertip.
- The 'Queen's official birthday' is celebrated in June, even though her actual birthday is in April.
- An average cloud weighs about 550 tons, roughly the same as 100 elephants.
- The British Isles are home to over 40 species of 'bumblebees'.
- Bubble wrap was originally intended to be used as three-dimensional wallpaper.
- The human nose can remember 50,000 different scents.

On this day

Day 196 of the year, 169 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Abhai (Syriac Orthodox Church); Christian feast day: Anne-Marie Javouhey; Christian feast day: Bernhard II, Margrave of Baden-Baden; Christian feast day: Bonaventure. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1971 — Jim Rash, American actor, comedian, and filmmaker
- 1948 — Twinkle, English singer-songwriter (died 2015)
- 1952 — David Pack, American singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer
- 1953 — Alicia Bridges, American singer-songwriter
- 1956 — Joe Satriani, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1952 — Terry O'Quinn, American actor
- 1952 — Johnny Thunders, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 1991)
- 1951 — Jesse Ventura, American wrestler, actor, and politician, 38th Governor of Minnesota

THE DAY TODAY

- 2012 — South Korean rapper Psy releases his hit single Gangnam Style.
- 1974 — In Nicosia, Cyprus, Greek junta-sponsored nationalists launch a coup d'état, deposing Makarios III and installing Nikos Sampson as the president of Cyprus.
- 2009 — Space Shuttle program: Endeavour is launched on STS-127 to complete assembly of the International Space Station's Kibō module.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1888 — The stratovolcano Mount Bandai erupts, killing approximately 500 people in Fukushima Prefecture, Japan.
- 1927 — Massacre of July 15, 1927: Eighty-nine protesters are killed by Austrian police in Vienna.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 2009 — Space Shuttle program: Endeavour is launched on STS-127 to complete assembly of the International Space Station's Kibō module.
- 1966 — Vietnam War: The United States and South Vietnam begin Operation Hastings to push the North Vietnamese out of the Vietnamese Demilitarized Zone.

- 2002 — The Anti-Terrorism Court of Pakistan sentences British born Ahmed Omar Saeed Sheikh to death, and three others suspected of murdering The Wall Street Journal reporter Daniel Pearl to life.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 197 of the year, 168 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: André de Soveral; Christian feast day: Gondulphus of Tongeren; Christian feast day: Helier; Christian feast day: Blessed Irmgard of Chiemsee. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1937 — John Daly, English director, producer, and screenwriter (died 2008)
- 1939 — William Bell, American singer-songwriter
- 1957 — Faye Grant, American actress
- 1928 — Anita Brookner, English novelist and art historian (died 2016)
- 2004 — Amiah Miller, American actress and model
- 1927 — Derek Hawsworth, English footballer (died 2021)
- 1927 — Shirley Hughes, English author and illustrator (died 2022)
- 1983 — Katrina Kaif, British Indian actress and model

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2004 — Millennium Park, considered Chicago's first and most ambitious early 21st-century architectural project, is opened to the public by Mayor Richard M. Daley.
- 2005 — An Antonov An-24 crashes near Baney in Bioko Norte, Equatorial Guinea, killing 60 people.
- 1990 — The Luzon earthquake strikes the Philippines with an intensity of 7.7, affecting Benguet, Pangasinan, Nueva Ecija, La Union, Aurora, Bataan, Zambales and Tarlac.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2013 — Syrian civil war: The Battle of Ras al-Ayn resumes between the People's Protection Units (YPG) and Islamist forces, beginning the Rojava–Islamist conflict.
- 1957 — KLM Flight 844 crashes off the Schouten Islands in present day Indonesia (then Netherlands New Guinea), killing 58 people.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026

FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)